



Worn
Gundidj

Social & Emotional Wellbeing

Participant Handbook

A culturally safe, strengths-based guide to your SEWB
journey with Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-operative.

REGISTERED NDIS PROVIDER

Provider number 4050163252

1-3 Rooneys Road, Warrnambool
VIC 3280

Phone (03) 5561 5315

ACKNOWLEDGEMENT OF COUNTRY

Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-operative acknowledges the Traditional Owners of the lands and waters across south-west Victoria where we live and work. We pay our respects to Elders past and present, and to all Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander people who use our services. Sovereignty was never ceded.

Welcome to Worn Gundidj

This handbook is for people receiving Social and Emotional Wellbeing (SEWB) support from Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-operative. It explains what you can expect from us, your rights, how we work, how we keep you safe, and how you can shape your own wellbeing and healing journey.

Our SEWB approach recognises that wellbeing is not only about an individual's mental health. It is holistic and interconnected — connection to Country, culture, family and kinship, community, spirituality and ancestors, mind and emotions, and body. Your strengths, identity, relationships, hopes and sense of belonging matter.

You do not have to read this all at once. We can yarn through it with you, explain it in plain language, give it to you in Easy Read or large print, read it aloud, arrange an interpreter, or involve a family member, Elder, advocate or support person.

Participant name	
Preferred name	
Date provided	
Worker / program	

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Our commitment to you

- We will listen to you and believe your experience.
- We will respect your identity, culture, language, family, kinship and beliefs.
- We will support your right to self-determination and choice.
- We will work at your pace, in places where you feel safe and comfortable.
- We will build on your strengths, resilience, hope, connection and capability.
- We will recognise healing, grief, loss and trauma without defining you by them.
- We will support connection to Country, culture, community and family where you want this.
- We will involve Elders, respected people, family and significant others when you choose and where appropriate.
- We will be honest about what we can and cannot provide, and connect you with other supports when needed.
- We will protect your privacy and explain when information may need to be shared for safety or legal reasons.
- We will take concerns, complaints and cultural safety issues seriously and learn from your feedback.

01 Who we are

Worn Gundidj Aboriginal Co-operative Ltd is an Aboriginal Community Controlled Organisation based in Warrnambool, delivering services across south-west Victoria. The organisation has operated continuously since 1994 and is governed by a Board drawn from the community.

Worn Gundidj provides a range of services and can often connect people across programs. This handbook focuses on SEWB support. It sits alongside the Worn Gundidj NDIS Participant Handbook, your service agreement, intake and consent processes, and our policies — you can ask for a copy of any of these.

VISIT

1-3 Rooneys Road
Warrnambool VIC 3280

PHONE

(03) 5561 5315
[Office hours]

YOUR WORKER

Name: _____
Ph: _____

02

What Social & Emotional Wellbeing means here

SEWB is a holistic way of understanding wellbeing. It includes mental health, but does not reduce wellbeing to symptoms or a diagnosis. It recognises the relationships between a person, their family and kinship, community, culture, Country, spirituality and body — and the history and circumstances that shape our lives.

The SEWB model below (Gee, Dudgeon, Schultz, Hart & Kelly, 2014) underpins the national SEWB framework and Victoria's *Balit Murrup: Aboriginal social emotional wellbeing framework 2017–2027*. It has seven connected domains, shaped by social, historical, political and cultural determinants.

**SOCIAL
DETERMINANTS**

**HISTORICAL
DETERMINANTS**

**CULTURAL
DETERMINANTS**

**POLITICAL
DETERMINANTS**



Each circle is a "connection to...". SEWB model adapted from Gee et al. (2014).

This means your support may include practical, emotional, cultural, social and connection-focused goals — not only clinical or individual goals.

03 Your SEWB rights

You have the right to...

- ✓ Be treated with dignity, respect and kindness.
- ✓ Be free from racism, discrimination, violence, abuse, neglect, exploitation and harassment.
- ✓ Make your own decisions, and be supported to make informed choices.
- ✓ Choose whether family, kin, Elders, advocates or other support people are involved.
- ✓ Receive information in a way you understand, including a free interpreter.
- ✓ See the information we keep about you, and ask for it to be corrected.
- ✓ Have an advocate, and complain without fear of losing your support.
- ✓ Have Sorry Business and cultural obligations recognised when supports are scheduled.
- ✓ Have your culture and identity respected and supported.
- ✓ Be welcomed and safe whatever your gender, sexuality or identity — including Sistergirls and Brotherboys.
- ✓ Have time to think, yarn, ask questions and involve people you trust.
- ✓ Say no, change your mind or withdraw consent without penalty — subject to lawful safety or reporting obligations.
- ✓ Privacy and confidentiality, with a clear explanation of the limits.
- ✓ Make decisions that involve reasonable risk, with support to understand and manage that risk.
- ✓ Ask for an Aboriginal worker, a worker of a particular gender, or another culturally appropriate arrangement where possible.
- ✓ Be involved in planning, reviewing and changing your supports.

These rights reflect the *Charter of Human Rights and Responsibilities Act 2006* (Vic) — including section 19, which protects the distinct cultural rights of Aboriginal people — the NDIS Code of Conduct, and Victoria's Social Services Standards.

04 First Peoples practice: what cultural safety looks like

Cultural safety is decided by you — the person receiving the service — not by the worker or the organisation.

It means more than acknowledging culture. It means we listen, respond respectfully and avoid anything that makes you feel unsafe, stereotyped, judged, excluded or that you have to justify who you are.

Connection to Country, culture, family and community can be central to wellbeing. We will ask what matters to you rather than assume what culture means for you. You do not have to share cultural information you do not want to share — your identity, connections and stories belong to you. We will not ask you to prove your Aboriginality to receive Worn Gundidj services.

With your agreement, support may include cultural strengthening, time on Country, family tracing or kinship connection, yarning with an Elder or respected person, community activities, cultural groups or links to other Aboriginal services. Our workers take part in ongoing cultural safety training and reflective supervision.

05 Self-determination and supported decision-making

Your life is yours to lead. Our role is to help you understand choices, risks and opportunities — not to take over decisions that belong to you.

Good supported decision-making means we:

give you information before you need to decide • use language and communication that work for you • give you enough time • support you to involve people you trust • explain realistic options • respect your will, preferences, values and goals • help you build confidence to make more decisions yourself.

Dignity of risk means you can make choices that carry risk. Where a decision involves significant risk, we will talk it through honestly, plan with you how to reduce the risk, and record what we agreed.

06 A holistic SEWB assessment

Your first conversations are not about fitting you into a category. They are about understanding who you are, what is happening for you, what has helped before, what matters now, and what you want your life to look like.

Depending on what you want to talk about, we may explore:

Preferred name & communication

Mob, family, kinship & Country

Language & interpreters

Housing

Work, study & money

Physical health

Mental health & emotional wellbeing

Alcohol & other drugs

Grief, loss & Sorry Business

Racism & discrimination

Family & community relationships

Safety concerns

Strengths, interests & hopes

Other services you use

Short, medium & longer-term goals

You do not have to cover every topic at once. Assessment helps us understand your whole life so you can decide what support is useful. Where it helps, we may use a culturally appropriate wellbeing tool with you and explain what it is for.

07 Your SEWB Healing Journey Plan

Your Healing Journey Plan is developed **with** you. It reflects your own priorities, not a worker's idea of what your goals should be. You will get a copy. Your plan can include:

- what you want to change or strengthen
- what keeps you strong
- people, places, culture and activities that support you
- practical steps toward your goals
- who you want involved
- what workers will do, and what you will do
- early signs you are becoming overwhelmed
- what helps you feel safe and grounded
- a safety plan, if needed
- when and how you want to review it

Goals can change — a healing journey is not always a straight line. We will review your plan with you at least every [3 / 6] months, or sooner if your circumstances change. **Your planning pages are over the page.**

My Healing Journey Plan

Started: _____ Review: _____

What keeps me strong

People, culture, places, beliefs, things I'm good at

What I want to change or strengthen

In my own words

My goal	Steps I'll take	Who helps	By when

Early signs I'm not travelling well

What I notice, what others notice

What helps me feel safe and grounded

Things I can do, places I can go

If I need help quickly

Person I trust: _____

Phone: _____

My worker: _____

Phone: _____

13YARN (24/7): 13 92 76

Emergency: 000

People I want involved: _____

I have a copy of my plan: ☐ Yes

My signature: _____

Worker signature: _____

08 Healing, trauma-informed support and recovery

Many people carry the effects of personal, family, community and intergenerational trauma, including the ongoing impacts of colonisation and the Stolen Generations. We will not assume trauma explains everything about you, and we will never require you to retell painful experiences to receive support.

A trauma-informed, healing-informed approach means we pay attention to:

Safety

physical, emotional
and cultural

Trust

being clear, honest
and reliable

Choice & control

you lead, we follow your pace

Relationships

working together, side by side

Strengths

what is strong, not what
is wrong

Culture

culture as a source of healing

Healing may include cultural, spiritual, family, community, practical and therapeutic pathways — depending on what you want. When you are distressed, we will help you feel safe and settled first; listen without judgement; focus on what you can manage now; give practical help; support connection to people, culture, Country and community; and work with other services so you don't have to tell your story again and again.

09 Yarning and relationship

Relationship is at the heart of good SEWB practice. We aim to create places that feel welcoming, comfortable and respectful. Depending on the program and what you prefer, support may happen at a Worn Gundidj site, out in community, during a practical activity, through outreach, by phone or video, or somewhere else we agree on.

A yarn is not a test. You can take your time, ask questions, pause, change the subject or bring someone with you. We will explain professional boundaries and confidentiality clearly — especially where a worker already knows you, your family or your community.

10 Family, kinship, Elders and community

Family and kinship can be central to wellbeing and decision-making. **You decide who you regard as family or kin, and who you want involved.**

With your agreement, we may work alongside family members, Elders, respected people, community members or other supports. We will respect cultural authority and your wishes about who should be involved.

Sometimes family or community involvement is not safe, or not wanted. We will respect this and work with you to find safer supports. We will never share your information with family without your consent, unless the law requires it (see section 15).

11 Culture, Country, spirituality and connection

Your Healing Journey Plan can include goals about:

- returning to or spending time on Country
- cultural activities, language or cultural learning
- connecting with Mob or family, including family tracing
- community events and groups
- Elders and cultural mentors
- spirituality, faith or connection to ancestors
- cultural identity, pride and belonging
- grief, Sorry Business and cultural obligations

Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander communities and peoples are diverse.

We will not assume that all Aboriginal people share the same culture, beliefs, Country or preferences. We will ask you what is right for you. If you are not Aboriginal or Torres Strait Islander, we will respect your culture, faith and background in the same way.

12 Mental health, alcohol and other drugs

SEWB support can include yarns about mental health, emotional wellbeing, and alcohol and other drug use. These are often connected with housing, family, grief, trauma, money stress, justice involvement and physical health.

You will be treated as a whole person — not as a diagnosis or a substance-use history. We use a **harm reduction** approach: we meet you where you are, without judgement, and support the goals you choose, whether that is cutting down, using more safely or stopping. You do not have to stop using to get support from us.

Where specialist treatment would help, we will support referral and work alongside GPs, AOD treatment and mental health services — with your consent.

EMERGENCY
000

13YARN • 24/7
13 92 76

DIRECTLINE AOD • 24/7
1800 888 236

13 Safety, violence, abuse, neglect and exploitation

Worn Gundidj has zero tolerance for violence, abuse, neglect and exploitation. Abuse can be physical, sexual, emotional, financial, cultural, spiritual or technology-based (such as tracking your phone or controlling your accounts). Neglect means failing to provide care or support that should have been provided.

Tell us if you feel unsafe — even if the concern is about a worker, another participant, family or another service. Speak with any worker or manager, use our complaints process, or contact an outside body (page 18). We will believe you, put your safety first, and report to authorities when the law requires.

Family violence support (24/7): Safe Steps 1800 015 188 • 1800RESPECT 1800 737 732. **Djirra** (Aboriginal family violence support): 1800 105 303.

14 Child and family safety

Children and young people have the right to be safe, heard and connected to their culture. Worn Gundidj is a child safe organisation. We follow the **Victorian Child Safe Standards**, including Standard 1: creating a culturally safe environment where the diverse identities and experiences of Aboriginal children and young people are respected and valued.

Our intake may ask about children in your care, whether you and your children are safe at home, and whether there are any relevant orders or concerns. This helps us support your whole family.

Reporting concerns

In Victoria, some workers are mandatory reporters, and every adult must report a reasonable belief that a child has been sexually abused by an adult. Where the law requires a report, we will make it — and wherever it is safe, we will tell you first and keep supporting you.

Information sharing

Where we are a prescribed organisation, the Child Information Sharing Scheme and Family Violence Information Sharing Scheme allow us to share relevant information with other services to keep children safe or manage family violence risk — sometimes without consent. We use the MARAM framework to assess family violence risk.

If a worker is accused of harming a child, we will act immediately to keep children safe and notify the relevant authorities, including the Commission for Children and Young People where the Reportable Conduct Scheme applies.

If Child Protection is involved

You can ask us to support you through the process, explain what is happening, and help you connect with legal advice (Victorian Aboriginal Legal Service, 1800 064 865) and Aboriginal family services. Aboriginal children have the right to stay connected to family, community, culture and Country under the Aboriginal Child Placement Principle.

Young people can also call **Kids Helpline** 24/7 on 1800 55 1800.

15 Privacy, confidentiality and consent

Your information and your story belong to you. We only collect what we need to give you safe, appropriate support and to meet our legal, quality and funding responsibilities. We protect it under the *Privacy Act 1988* (Cth) and the *Health Records Act 2001* (Vic), and we respect the right of Aboriginal people to have a say in how data about them is collected and used (Indigenous Data Sovereignty).

Consent means you agree freely, with enough information to understand what you are agreeing to. You can ask questions, take time, involve a support person, say no, or withdraw consent at any time. We will ask separately before using photos, video, your story, or including you in research.

When we may share without consent

- to lessen a serious threat to someone's life, health or safety
- to keep a child safe, or manage family violence risk
- when a court order, subpoena or law requires it

Wherever it is safe and lawful, we will tell you first.

Your records

- You can ask to see your records and ask us to correct anything wrong. We will usually respond within 30 days.
- Records are stored securely and kept for at least 7 years after your last contact (until age 25 for children), as the law requires.

Our intake and consent forms explain the information-sharing arrangements for your service. We will check your consent again if things change.

Worried about your privacy? Tell us first if you can. You can also contact the Office of the Australian Information Commissioner (1300 363 992) or, for health information, the Health Complaints Commissioner (1300 582 113).

16 Advocates and support people

You can have an advocate, family member, Elder, friend or support person with you at any time. An advocate can help you understand your rights, say what you want, prepare for meetings and make a complaint.

You choose who supports you. If you want an independent advocate but do not have one, we can help you find an advocacy service. Using an advocate will never affect your supports.

Victorian Aboriginal Legal Service

Legal help and advocacy • 1800 064 865

Independent Mental Health Advocacy

If you are on a compulsory mental health order • 1300 947 820

Disability advocacy

Find a free advocate at the Disability Advocacy Finder (askizzy.org.au/disability-advocacy-finder)

Djirra

Support and legal help for Aboriginal people experiencing family violence • 1800 105 303

17 Accessibility and communication

You should be able to understand information about your supports. Ask us for:

Easy Read

Large print

Information read aloud

A free interpreter

Auslan

Phone or video appointments

An accessible meeting place

Your own communication aids

Tell us what helps you communicate, and what makes appointments easier or safer for you.

Translating and Interpreting Service (TIS National): 131 450 • **National Relay Service** (if you are Deaf or have a hearing or speech impairment): 133 677, or Speak and Listen 1300 555 727.

18 Worker standards and boundaries

Our workers are expected to act respectfully, honestly, safely and within their role, and to follow the NDIS Code of Conduct and our own code of conduct. Before working with you, workers must hold the screening checks their role requires — such as a Working with Children Check, NDIS Worker Screening Check and police check — and the right training and qualifications. They receive regular supervision.

You can ask to see a worker's ID. You can ask for a different worker — including because of gender or cultural preference — and you do not need to explain why.

Professional boundaries — workers must not:

- misuse their role or pressure you
- have a romantic or sexual relationship with you
- add you on their personal social media
- accept money, gifts or favours beyond a small token
- make decisions about your supports for their own interests
- share your information with their family or community

In a close community, a worker may already know you or your family. If so, they will tell their manager, and we will talk with you about how to keep your support private and comfortable — including offering another worker.

19 Money, property and conflicts of interest

Your money and belongings are yours. Workers will never borrow or lend money, ask for your bank card or PIN, ask you to sign anything you don't understand, or be named in your will. Any time a worker handles money for you as part of a support, it will be agreed with you, receipted and recorded.

A **conflict of interest** is when personal or organisational interests could unfairly influence a decision about you. Conflicts must be declared and managed. You are never required to choose Worn Gundidj for one service just because you receive another service from us.

20 Incidents and emergencies

An incident is something that has harmed, or could have harmed, you or another person. Near misses are recorded too, because learning from them prevents future harm. After an incident we will:

1

Make everyone safe and get urgent help

2

Record it, and report it to regulators when required

3

Tell you openly what happened and say sorry

4

Investigate, with your input

5

Learn and make changes

This is called **open disclosure**. For emergencies, call 000. For bushfire, flood and other warnings, use the VicEmergency app or website and follow local emergency directions.

21 Feedback, complaints and cultural safety concerns

You have the right to complain, give feedback, make a suggestion or tell us that something went well. Complaints can be about a worker, a service, a decision, cultural safety, privacy, communication, discrimination, safety or anything else that matters to you.

How to tell us

- talk to your worker or ask for a manager
- phone (03) 5561 5315
- email feedback@worn Gundidj.org.au
- write to us, or tell us anonymously
- ask an advocate, family member or Elder to help

What happens next

- we acknowledge it within [2] business days
- we keep you updated and aim to resolve it within [21] days
- cultural safety concerns can go to a senior Aboriginal staff member
- we tell you the outcome, and how to take it further

Making a complaint will never cost you your support. You do not have to come to us first — you can go straight to an outside body (next page).

Who you can contact outside Worn Gundidj

You can contact these independent bodies at any time, with or without telling us first.

Organisation	For concerns about	Phone
NDIS Quality and Safeguards Commission	NDIS-funded supports and workers	1800 035 544
Mental Health and Wellbeing Commission	Public mental health services in Victoria	1800 246 054
Health Complaints Commissioner	Health services and health records in Victoria	1300 582 113
Victorian Equal Opportunity and Human Rights Commission	Racism, discrimination and human rights	1300 292 153
Commission for Children and Young People	Child safety in organisations	1300 782 978
Office of the Australian Information Commissioner	Privacy	1300 363 992
Social Services Regulator (Vic)	Registered social services, e.g. family violence and homelessness	vic.gov.au

22 Starting with Worn Gundidj

- 1 First contact or referral.** You, a family member or another service can contact us.
- 2 A first yarn** about what is happening for you and what you want.
- 3 Holistic assessment** of your strengths, needs and any risks — such as housing, health, AOD, family, Country and safety. You don't have to cover everything at once.
- 4 Consent and information-sharing** decisions, explained in plain language.
- 5 Your goals and Healing Journey Plan,** connecting with the workers, Elders, family or services you choose.
- 6 Regular review** so your support keeps fitting your life.

23 Changing, cancelling or rescheduling support

Life happens and plans change. Let us know as early as you can if you need to change or cancel an appointment. We will consider Sorry Business and cultural obligations, emergencies, illness and other circumstances, and we will try to reschedule.

If you miss appointments and we can't reach you, we may check in with you — or with a contact person you have agreed to — to make sure you are okay.

NDIS-funded supports: cancellation rules are set out in your service agreement, the Worn Gundidj NDIS Participant Handbook and the current NDIS Pricing Arrangements. Ask us if you are unsure.

24 Leaving, transitioning and returning

You can choose to leave a service at any time. Where it helps, we will work with you on a transition plan so important supports do not just stop. With your consent, we can link you with another provider and share the information needed for a safe handover.

If Worn Gundidj needs to end or change a service — for example because funding changes — we will tell you as early as possible, explain why in writing, and help you find other support.

Before you go

We review your goals together and celebrate what you've achieved.

Handover

With your consent, we connect you with your next supports.

Feedback

We'll ask how your time with us went, so we can improve.

You are always welcome back.

If you return to Worn Gundidj later, we will look at your current circumstances and needs rather than assume nothing has changed.

25

Quality, accountability and the standards we follow

Quality is not only about compliance. It is about whether people experience services that are safe, effective, connected and person-centred — and whether we listen and learn.

We use your feedback, complaints, incidents, service information, supervision, staff learning and Board governance to find ways to improve. We invite people who use our services to help us understand what is working and what needs to change.

For SEWB, quality also means asking whether our practice is culturally safe, strengths-based, trauma-informed, connected, respectful of self-determination, and responsive to family, community and Country.

Laws, standards and frameworks that guide our SEWB work

National Agreement on Closing the Gap

Strengthening Aboriginal community-controlled services

National SEWB Strategic Framework 2017–2023

The national SEWB model and principles

Korin Korin Balit-Djak (2017–2027)

Victorian Aboriginal health, wellbeing and safety plan

Victorian Social Services Standards

Overseen by the Social Services Regulator

MARAM Framework & information sharing schemes

Family violence risk and child wellbeing

Mental Health and Wellbeing Act 2022 (Vic)

Rights and principles in mental health care

Gayaa Dhuwi (Proud Spirit) Declaration

Aboriginal leadership in mental health and SEWB

Balit Murrup (2017–2027)

Victoria's Aboriginal SEWB framework

NDIS Practice Standards & Code of Conduct

For NDIS-funded supports and workers

Victorian Child Safe Standards

Keeping children and young people safe

Charter of Human Rights and Responsibilities Act 2006 (Vic)

Including Aboriginal cultural rights

Privacy Act 1988 (Cth) & Health Records Act 2001 (Vic)

How your information is protected

You can ask for a copy of any Worn Gundidj policy mentioned in this handbook.

26 What good SEWB support should feel like

Good support should help you feel...

Heard

*rather
than*

talked over

Respected

*rather
than*

judged

Safe

*rather
than*

threatened

Connected

*rather
than*

isolated

Supported

*rather
than*

controlled

Hopeful

*rather
than*

defined by problems

In charge of your choices

*rather
than*

having choices made for you

...proud of your identity, strengths and connections, and able to build skills and supports that stay useful long after you leave our service.

If your experience doesn't feel like this, please tell us.

Your feedback is how we improve. Write a note here and hand it to any worker, or use any of the ways on page 17.

27 Words we use

SEWB

Social and Emotional Wellbeing — a holistic, connected understanding of wellbeing.

Self-determination

Your right to make decisions about your life, identity, community and wellbeing.

Cultural safety

Practice that respects identity and is free of racism, stereotyping and cultural harm — as decided by you.

Country

A living connection to land, waters, people, culture, ancestors and place, as defined by the person and community.

Sorry Business

Cultural practices and obligations around death, mourning and grief.

Strengths-based

Focusing on abilities, relationships, resilience and hopes — not only problems.

Dignity of risk

Your right to make choices that involve some risk, with support to stay as safe as possible.

Advocate

An independent person who helps you understand and use your rights.

MARAM

Victoria's framework for identifying, assessing and managing family violence risk.

NDIS / NDIA

National Disability Insurance Scheme, run by the National Disability Insurance Agency.

ACCO

Aboriginal Community Controlled Organisation — run by and for the local Aboriginal community.

Supported decision-making

Getting the support you need to make your own decisions, rather than having them made for you.

Kinship

Family and relationship systems that can reach well beyond a household or Western ideas of family.

Mob

A word many Aboriginal people use for their family, community or people.

Trauma-informed

An approach that understands the effects of trauma and puts safety, trust, choice and control first.

Harm reduction

Reducing the harms from alcohol and other drug use without judgement, whatever your goals.

Consent

Agreeing freely, with enough information to understand what you are agreeing to.

Open disclosure

Being honest with you about an incident: what happened, saying sorry, and what we will change.

Social Services Regulator

The Victorian body that registers and oversees many social services.

NDIS Commission

NDIS Quality and Safeguards Commission — the independent regulator of NDIS providers and workers.